the Turks to be more reasonable, but there is no telling whether we shall have a fight or not yet.[63] The Turks began the negociations by demanding that the Persians should give back to them or make good, the cannon and other warlike stores which they lost at the battle of Topreh Kaleh, where the Persians beat them, in, I think, the year 1823, and after which they made peace[64] which peace has never been broken until within the last twelve month, if the skirmishes on the frontier can be called, breaking the peace between the two countries. In case of a war we should have manufactures (Manchester) up forty or fifty per ct almost immediately, because the roads being impassable the supply would be stopped from this end, but it would be a long time ere we could get supplied from the other viz: Bombay, Benderi, Busheer and Meeraz, and even when they did come the extra land carriage would make them very dear. Some of these goods have lately been brought to Tehran from Baghdad, but I doubt whether this line will answer to any extent yet. The traffic on the river between that town and Bussora is so dangerous and uncertain on account of the disturbed state of the Arab tribes on its banks. If the navigation of the river was unimpeded the importers by way of Bussora and Baghdad would certainly be able to undersell at Tehran those by way of Busheer and Meeraz and perhaps even those of this northern route viz. Constantinople, Trebizonde and Erzeroom: because they would save a great deal in land carriage. This line of trade is yet in its infancy and I doubt much whether it will succeed on account of the reason above stated and because the Persian Baghdad frontier is always disturbed and from the nature of the inhabitants always likely to be so.

Mr Bonham was to have been married in July and we expect him here with his wife in October, Mr Abbott then goes to Tehran. We do not know who is to be ambassador here, Mr Ellis is talked of, would that Charles had not quarreled with him. Col Shiel is now acting as Chargé d'Affaires and has been since Sir John McNeill's departure, but he does not expect to be confirmed, because his brother is on the wrong side in politics and moreover the said Colonel has saved a good deal of money, is in bad health, and wants to get home. I continue to translate the newspapers for the Prince for which I get nothing as yet but it may lead to something. He gave me a Cashmeer shawl worth nine or ten pounds.

[63] After a series of increasingly serious border incidents in 1842, Persian religious opinion was outraged by an attack on Kerbela and a massacre of its inhabitants. Although this city was on Turkish soil, it had long been considered a Shi'a shrine, and there was a popular demand for war with Turkey. Extensive military preparations were made, but England and Russia intervened in the role of mediators, especially for the purpose of delimiting the Turco-Persian border. Curiously, this joint mediation board continued on and off until 1914(!), when the border was finally officially defined.

[64] The treaty of Erzerum concluded the hostilities of 1821–1823. The battle of Topreh Kaleh, the final battle of that war, was won by the Persians against greatly superior numbers.

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